

Michael's 5-Day Machine Routine

Planet Fitness · Machines only, no free weights

Goal: Muscle & Strength

Level: Beginner

5 days / week

30–40 min

Shoulder-friendly

Start here, Michael — read this first. Since you're just getting started, do **2 sets** of each exercise for your first week or two. That gives you time to learn each machine and how it should feel before you push the weight. Once the movements click, bump up to **3 sets**. And if five days feels like a lot at first, no problem — run just Days 1–3 for a couple weeks, then add Days 4–5 once the routine feels like a habit. Good form and showing up consistently will get you further than lifting heavy this early. You've got this.

Looking after your shoulders. A little muscle burn is normal and fine. **Sharp or pinching pain is not** — if you feel that, stop the movement. To keep your shoulders happy: warm them up first, only press as far as feels comfortable (never force it), use a **neutral, palms-facing grip** whenever a machine offers one, and don't skip the rear-delt work on Days 2 and 4 — those little exercises are exactly what keep your shoulders strong and healthy.

The week at a glance

DAY 1

Chest & Triceps

DAY 2

Back & Biceps

DAY 3

Legs & Core

DAY 4

Shoulders &
Arms

DAY 5

Full Body &
Core

Pick any 5 days that fit your week — they don't have to be Monday through Friday. Just aim for at least one full rest day. Every session starts with the warm-up and ends with the cooldown below.

Every session: warm-up & cooldown

Warm-up (~5 min)

- 5 minutes easy cardio — treadmill, bike, or elliptical, just enough to break a light sweat.
- 10 slow arm circles each direction + 10 shoulder rolls (primes the shoulders).
- First set of the first machine: use a light weight as a "feeler" set before working weight.

Cooldown (~5 min)

- 3–5 minutes of easy walking to bring the heart rate down.
- Gentle stretches for the muscles worked that day — hold each ~20–30 sec, no bouncing.
- Hydrate; aim for some protein within a couple hours.

The workouts

DAY 1

4–5 machines
~35 min

Chest & Triceps

EXERCISE (MACHINE)	SETS × REPS	REST
Chest Press Machine Push handles, don't lock elbows hard. Neutral grip if available.	3 × 8–12	60–90s
Pec Deck / Chest Fly Machine Squeeze chest, stop when arms are in line with body — no over-stretch.	3 × 10–12	60s
Assisted Dip Machine (triceps) Stay upright, elbows close. Use more assist weight to make it easier.	3 × 8–12	60s
Triceps Pushdown (cable machine) Elbows pinned to sides, straighten arms, control the way up.	3 × 10–12	60s
Ab Crunch Machine (optional)	2 × 12–15	45s

DAY 2**Back & Biceps**

5 machines

~35 min

EXERCISE (MACHINE)	SETS × REPS	REST
Lat Pulldown Machine Pull the bar to upper chest, lead with the elbows, no leaning way back.	3 × 8–12	60–90s
Seated Row Machine Squeeze shoulder blades together, chest tall, don't shrug up.	3 × 8–12	60–90s
Assisted Pull-Up Machine Same machine as the dip. Higher assist = easier. Great back builder.	2 × 6–10	60s
Biceps Curl Machine Control the lower, no swinging. Full but comfortable range.	3 × 10–12	60s
Reverse Pec Deck (Rear Delts) Shoulder-health gold. Light weight, squeeze the back of the shoulders.	3 × 12–15	45s

DAY 3**Legs & Core**

5–6 machines

~40 min

EXERCISE (MACHINE)	SETS × REPS	REST
Leg Press Machine Feet mid-platform, lower until knees ~90°, don't let the lower back round off the seat.	3 × 10–12	90s
Leg Extension Machine Straighten knees smoothly, pause 1 sec at top, lower slowly.	3 × 10–12	60s
Seated / Lying Leg Curl Machine Works the hamstrings. Controlled curl, don't jerk the pad.	3 × 10–12	60s
Hip Abductor & Adductor Machines Do both (out and in). Slow and controlled each way.	2 × 12–15	45s
Calf Raise (on Leg Press) Push through the balls of the feet, full stretch at the bottom.	3 × 12–15	45s

DAY 4

Shoulders & Arms

5 machines

~35 min

EXERCISE (MACHINE)	SETS × REPS	REST
Shoulder Press Machine ⚠ go light Neutral grip if available. Press only as high as is pain-free. If pressing bothers the shoulder at all, skip this and add a set to the two moves below.	3 × 10–12	75s
Lateral Raise Machine Lead with the elbows, raise to about shoulder height — not higher. Light weight.	3 × 12–15	45s
Reverse Pec Deck (Rear Delts) Again — keeps the shoulders balanced and healthy. Squeeze and control.	3 × 12–15	45s
Biceps Curl Machine Smooth up, slow down, no momentum.	3 × 10–12	60s
Triceps Pushdown (cable machine) Elbows locked to sides, full extension.	3 × 10–12	60s

DAY 5

Full Body & Core

5 machines

~35 min

EXERCISE (MACHINE)	SETS × REPS	REST
Chest Press Machine A lighter, quicker revisit — focus on smooth reps.	2 × 10–12	60s
Lat Pulldown Machine Pull to the chest, full squeeze at the bottom.	2 × 10–12	60s
Leg Press Machine Higher reps today, controlled.	2 × 12–15	75s
Back Extension Machine (low back — easy) Small, controlled range. Stop at a straight torso, never over-arch.	2 × 12–15	60s
Ab Crunch Machine Curl the ribs toward the hips, exhale on the crunch.	3 × 15	45s

How to make it work — coaching notes

Picking your starting weight

For each machine, pick a weight where you can hit the **top of the rep range with about 2 reps still in the tank**. The last couple reps should feel like real work, but your form should never fall apart. When in doubt, go a little lighter your first session and jot down the number so you know where to start next time.

Adding weight over time — this is what gets results

This is the real secret to building muscle and strength. Once you can finish **all your sets at the top of the rep range with good form**, add the smallest amount of weight next session (one plate or one pin on the stack) and settle back into the range. Small, steady jumps beat big ones every time.

Reps & tempo

- Rep range 8–12 for building muscle.
- Lower for ~2 seconds, lift for ~1 second — always controlled.
- Exhale on the effort (the push/pull), inhale on the return.
- No swinging or using momentum.

Recovery & consistency

- Rest 60–90 sec between sets (a little longer on legs).
- Take at least one full rest day each week.
- Sleep, water, and protein build your results as much as the gym does.
- Write down your weights each session — watching them climb is motivating.

A quick word on "no free weights." Everything here is a machine or cable you'll find at Planet Fitness — no barbells or dumbbells required. Machines are a great, safe way to build a strong base, and as you get more comfortable and stronger over the coming weeks, you'll have a solid foundation to grow from.

coming back, check with a doctor or physical therapist before continuing.